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The primary object of an efficient police is the prevention of crime: the next ... detection and punishment of offenders ...

Richard Mayne
British justice of the peace
(1796–1868)

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rather than the army's red, and were unarmed. Police constables (known as “bobbies” or “peelers” after Robert Peel) were paid more than a laborer but less than a skilled worker and, to stem corruption, they were no longer allowed to take fees for recovering stolen goods. Until 1897, constables were banned from voting in elections to show that they had no political allegiance.

The new police force was the first to prioritize crime prevention, patrolling streets and keeping order by working with the local community. At first, people were hostile; they felt that uniformed officers telling them what to do was too much state interference in their daily lives. However, as crime levels across London began to fall, public opinion started to shift.

Going nationwide

By 1835, many newly formed local councils were appointing paid constables. The Rural Constabulary Act of 1839 allowed counties to establish their own police forces. Professional forces slowly spread across Britain, each overseen by a centralized command with power derived from the law itself—

Parliament. The County and Borough Police Act of 1856 then required all British towns and counties to establish their own police forces. By 1900, there were 181 police forces across Britain, but communication between them was scant, so many country forces were amalgamated into regional police forces to foster greater cooperation in policing across the nation.

Adopting the British model

Many Commonwealth countries and the US based their police forces on the British model, which focused on crime prevention and community ties and was viewed as less open to corruption than municipal police forces in continental Europe. The first centralized municipal US police force was formed in 1838 in Boston, with New York following soon after in 1845. However, the US police system soon diverged, as it became decentralized and based on local communities—often with strong ties to local politics, making some forces open to corruption.

Today, Britain's police service has expanded its remit to include crime detection, undercover policing, anti-terrorism, and fighting cybercrime. Yet, at its root, it is still based on the 1829 principle that the police and the public are synonymous. ■

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The police are the public and the public are the police.

Metropolitan Police's General Instructions, 1829

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Robert Peel

Father of modern policing and son of a wealthy industrialist and baronet, Sir Robert Peel was born in 1788 and educated at Harrow and Oxford University. He entered the UK Parliament as a Conservative MP in 1809 and held a number of important roles, including chief secretary for Ireland from 1812 to 1818. But it was as home secretary from 1822 that Peel was to leave his mark, instigating prison reform and establishing the Metropolitan Police.

Peel later served twice as prime minister, in 1834–1835 and 1841–1846. In 1846, he successfully repealed the Corn Laws (trade restrictions and tariffs designed to protect domestic grain producers) to free up grain to send to Ireland and relieve the potato famine there. He also introduced the Factory Act of 1844, restricting the number of hours women and children could be made to work in factories. This, coupled with the Mines Act of 1842—which banned women and children from working in the mines—was significant in the reform of Victorian working practices. He died in 1850, after a fatal fall from his horse.